

United Nations Education, Scientific, and Cultural Organization

Thomas Jefferson Model United Nations Conference

TechMUN XXXIII



Middle School General Assembly

Co-Chairs: Chi Do and Ronit Singh

Thomas Jefferson High School for Science and Technology

Dear Delegates,

It is our great pleasure to welcome you to TechMUN XXXIII and the United Nations Education, Scientific, and Cultural Organization! We are both sophomores at TJ and are ecstatic to be your co-chairs for this committee! Over the conference, we will be discussing some of UNESCO's most important issues, including Preserving Indigenous Lands Against Environmental Destruction and Ensuring Equal Access to Girl's Education Worldwide. Each of you will represent a country, and we're excited to see your ideas and the solutions you bring to the table.

This committee will focus on international challenges that have a long-lasting impact in our current society. We are looking for delegates who can think creatively while also proposing thoughtful and practical solutions. Active participation, meaningful debate, and respectful collaboration will be key to a successful committee. As your co-chairs we encourage attention-grabbing speeches, leadership, teamwork, and diplomacy.

While committee is a place for debate and competition, it's also a safe space to step out of your comfort zone and try new things. Challenge yourself by giving speeches without notes, leading a bloc, or sharing ideas even if you're unsure. Everyone starts out somewhere in MUN, and it's very important to remember that committee is a learning experience, so don't worry about making mistakes. Whether this is your first committee or you're a returning delegate, we hope you get something out of this conference.

Most importantly, we want this experience to be fun! If you have any questions before the conference, feel free to reach out at unescotechmun2026@gmail.com. We can't wait to see you!

Chi Do & Ronit Singh

Co-Chairs, United Nations Education, Scientific and Cultural Organization

Topic 1: Preserving Indigenous Lands Against Environmental Destruction

Introduction:

Indigenous lands refer to the territories that the Indigenous people of the world use. The lands are controlled by cultural traditions that have been passed down from generation to generation. They are closely associated with the identity, spirituality, and overall ways of life of the Indigenous people. The Indigenous lands are not only significant to the cultural identity of the Indigenous people but also to the biodiversity of the world. They are identified as estimated to 50% of more of the world's lands, including most of the world's pristine ecosystems and 54% of the world's remaining intact forests. These territories are of utmost significance to the conservation of forests, wildlife, freshwater systems, and the regulation of climate change.

However, despite the significant contributions of the Indigenous People to the natural environment, they have yet to be recognized and appreciated by the government. The fact that many of them have yet to see their lands being acknowledged and protected by the government, despite the fact that the lands have been threatened by human activities such as industry and agriculture, speaks for itself. These activities include large-scale deforestation, mining, gas and oil drilling, and infrastructure development. Aside from the fact that the activities have a negative effect on the natural environment, it is a violation of the rights of the indigenous people. One of the rights being violated is the right to own the land and the right to give informed consent. As the threats to the indigenous people's lands have been on the increase, protecting the indigenous people's lands has been a global environmental issue.

Current Situation:

Indigenous territories are facing numerous environmental challenges, including deforestation, over-exploitation of resources, and the implementation of large-scale infrastructure. Deforestation activities such as logging and agricultural activities have led to the loss of biodiversity, such as the Gran Chaco forest in South America. Oil, gas, and mining activities have resulted in environmental degradation, such as the Amazon rainforest in Peru. Hydroelectric dams, such as the Belo Monte hydroelectric dam in Brazil, have resulted in the degradation of riverine ecosystems. Environmental exploitation is also a threat to indigenous populations, such as the Sierra Nevada mountain range in Colombia. However, indigenous territories that have recognized rights have lower biodiversity loss, proving the effectiveness of indigenous knowledge. The link between indigenous rights and the environment is supported by the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples.

Possible Solutions:

Some solutions that could be implemented to preserve the lands of the Indigenous are strengthening the rights, promoting sustainability, and ensuring accountability. The government should recognize the ownership of the lands by the Indigenous, ensuring that free, prior, and informed consent is obtained prior to the execution of any development project on these lands. The inclusion of the ecological knowledge of the Indigenous in the environmental policies of the country could be helpful, as it has already proved successful in maintaining the balance of nature. The international community could assist the Indigenous in the conservation of these lands by providing funds, technology, and training directly to them. The government could also

implement stronger environmental regulations, imposing sanctions on companies that do not comply with the environmental and human rights regulations.

Questions to Consider:

1. How can governments balance economic development with the protection of Indigenous lands and environmental sustainability?
2. What steps have to be taken to ensure Indigenous communities have participation in decisions that affect their lands?
3. How can international organizations like UNESCO better support the enforcement of Indigenous land rights?
4. What roles should corporations and private industries play in preventing environmental destruction of Indigenous territories?
5. What mechanisms can be used to hold governments and companies accountable for violating Indigenous rights and environmental protections?

Helpful Links:

- <https://www.unesco.org/en/links/biodiversity>
- <https://www.wri.org/insights/indigenous-and-local-community-land-rights-protect-biodiversity>
- <https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2025/may/07/a-cemetery-of-trees-vast-green-expanses-turned-to-dust-as-loggers-plunder-south-americas-gran-chaco>
- <https://apnews.com/article/brazil-amazon-rainforest-belo-monte-hydropower-6a8b015016297312305578a82bfd2a7c>

Topic 2: Ensuring Equal Access to Girls Education Worldwide

Introduction:

Education is one of the fundamental human rights and a key factor for social and economic development. However, millions of girls worldwide are still deprived of their right to equal opportunities for education due to inequality, cultural practices, poverty, and conflict. According to UNESCO, over 129 million girls worldwide are out of school, which includes 32 million girls at the primary school age, 30 million girls at the lower secondary school age, and 67 million girls at the upper secondary school age. Although significant progress has been achieved during the last decades, gender inequality in education persists and remains deeply rooted, especially in poor and conflict-affected countries.

Barriers to education for girls include social norms, domestic chores, child marriage, and poverty, which cause parents to value the education of boys more. These challenges are more pronounced in areas such as Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia, resulting in large gaps in gender. Uneducated girls are at a higher risk of marrying early, poor health, and economic dependence, while educated girls are more likely to earn more money, practice good health, and be productive in their communities. Schools also do not support girls due to insecure environments, poor sanitation and menstrual facilities, and gender-based violence. In conflict areas, these issues are worse, causing girls to be at a higher risk of dropping out of school and being exploited.

Current Situation

Yet, despite international agreements such as the achievement of Sustainable Development Goal 4, which focuses on the achievement of "Quality Education," and SDG 5,

which focuses on the achievement of "Gender Equality," the achievement of equal access to girls' education remains a challenge. This challenge has been worsened by the presence of conflicts, political instability, and the COVID-19 pandemic, which have hindered the achievement of the girls' education goal.

In addition, the presence of economic inequality and the divide between the "haves" and the "have-nots" in the context of access to digital technology also remains a challenge to the achievement of girls' education. Despite the fact that the use of technology has the potential to promote the achievement of girls' education, the lack of access to digital devices and the internet by girls remains a challenge. In some cases, girls are restricted by laws and policies from accessing education.

Possible Solutions:

In order to guarantee the equitable access of girls to their education across the globe, a multidimensional and concerted effort is a necessity. First and foremost, governments have to enhance their laws that safeguard the girl child's access to and right to education. This also involves the banning of child marriages and gender discrimination. Investing in school infrastructure that provides a safe and gender-responsive learning environment can greatly enhance the girl child's access to and retention in schools. In addition, increasing the availability of scholarships and school feeding programs can help reduce the economic burden of families and enhance the girl child's access to and retention in schools.

Community engagement and mobilization are also critical in the promotion of girls' access to and retention in schools. This involves engaging the community, parents, and the girl child in challenging gender discrimination and promoting the girl child's access to and retention in schools. The use of technology can also play a crucial role in the promotion of the girl child's

access to and retention in schools. This can be achieved by ensuring that the use of technology is equitable.

Questions to Consider:

- How can governments address cultural and social norms that limit girls' access to education without infringing on community autonomy?
 - What role can education systems play in protecting girls from violence and discrimination within and outside schools?
- How can technology be used to expand access to education while reducing the digital gender gap?
- In what ways can international organizations support girls' education in conflict and humanitarian settings?

Helpful Links:

- <https://www.unicef.org/education/girls-education>
- <https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/progress-girls-access-education-what-new-unesco-data-reveals>
- <https://www.unicef.org/reports/mapping-social-protection-intervention-pathways-address-barriers-girls-education>
- <https://www.worldbank.org/en/topic/education/publication/missed-opportunities-the-high-cost-of-not-educating-girls>
- <https://blogs.worldbank.org/en/education/closing-gap-tackling-remaining-disparities-girls-education-and-womens-labor-market>

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